THE THREE HINDI HEARTLAND STATES OF RAJASTHAN, MADHYA PRADESH AND CHHATTISGARH ARE AMONG the five going to the polls in November, and will be the launch pads for the Congress and Bharatiya Janata Party for the Lok Sabha election in 2024. In most of the 520 assembly seats in these states, the two behemoths of Indian politics will be engaged in direct combat.

If the BJP dominates national politics, the Congress is in power in two of the states and a strong challenger in the third. For the Grand Old Party, currently ruling six states (as junior alliance partner in two), protecting its turf is crucial. For the BJP, which rules 10 states on its own—four in the northeast—and three in alliance, winning these states will cement its place in the heartland.

Being the first big set of polls after 28 Opposition parties came together to form the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance, or INDIA, a comprehensive Congress win will energise the coalition. In fact, the success of the alliance depends hugely on the Congress performance in seats where it is in direct contest with the BJP. Of the 186 Lok Sabha seats where the two face off directly, 65 are in these three states, even though a superlative performance in state polls is no guarantee of victory in the Lok Sabha election. In 2018, the Congress cornered 282 of the 520 assembly seats in the three states, but it was the BJP that walked away with 62 of the 65 parliamentary seats a few months later. That said, the Narendra Modi-led BJP is not one to take chances and is giving these polls its all.

More so, because the Opposition parties' attempt to split the OBC (Other Backward Class) vote has jeopardised the social engineering strat-





THE INCUMBENT & THE CONTENDER (Top) Madhya Pradesh CM Shivraj Chouhan at a function in Bhopal, Oct. 4; MP Congress chief Kamal Nath addressing a poll rally in Shajapur, Sept. 30